

circle, important dates, names of pets and so on. Considering this, each bit of information that a hacker can piece together about their target will bring them closer to finding the password.

With this information at hand, a hacker can construct a dictionary of terms related to the target to improve their chances of getting to the password in a reasonable amount of time. Brute-forcing your way to the password is a time-consuming process, and can take days or even weeks. On the other hand, a little time social engineering, and you might possibly find your password in significantly lesser time. Why bash your way to the front door when there could be a key lying under a pot nearby?

So how does one do some social engineering? Here are some common techniques:

Shoulder Surfing: As you can probably understand from the phrase, shoulder surfing involves finding out the password by actually seeing someone type it in.

Dumpster Diving: It is literally the act of going through someone's garbage in the hope of learning something. Few people take care to properly dispose of sensitive documents.



Impersonation: We gave an example of someone impersonating a school authority to con a student's parent. In a similar manner, one might con an employee of an organization by impersonating a system administrator and point blank asking for the password. Similarly by impersonating customer service, one can over the phone convince people to give up their personal data.